OUR FINEST SHUTTLERS IN 2023, THEY WON THE ASIAN GAMES GOLD—THE FIRST FOR INDIA IN BADMINTON—BESIDES FOUR OTHER TITLES, CLAIMING THE WORLD #1 RANK ON THE WAY

By Suhani Singh



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bog them down mentally. The Indian pair came up trumps—beating the Malaysians comprehensively in straight games—at the Indonesia Open in June and then at the all-important Asian Games.

Such success means they now enter tournaments with the 'favourites' tag. Developing a saintly calm that can absorb such pressure is still work in progress, as evident from how they fell to the lower-ranked Danish duo of Kim Astrup and Anders Rasmussen in front of a partisan crowd at the World Championships quarter-finals in Copenhagen in August.

The SatChi Express isn't the sort to rest on its laurels. The year 2024 beckons: Paris glitters with the allure of an Olympic medal

SEVEN YEARS AND COUNTING

- Have been on-court partners for seven years. Communication in the first year was difficult with Andhra Pradesh's Satwiksairaj speaking little Hindi and Maharashtra's Chirag not acquainted with Telugu

- **RECORD SMASHER** Satwiksairaj holds the Guinness World Record for the fastest smash at 565 kmph

But the intent is clear and unfogged. "We want to *meet* those expectations," says Satwiksairaj. Some of that laser focus is also owed to Danish coach Mathias Boe, who brought in a methodical approach with a well-laid-out training and game calendar and tactical inputs. "We know well in advance what works well for us, what doesn't, what we need to work on," says Chirag. Satwiksairaj waxes eloquent on how Mathias ingrained a sense of discipline in them. "The professionalism has rubbed off on us," he says. "There's proper food, rest, and we take care of our bodies."

The SatChi Express isn't the sort to rest on its laurels. The year 2024, especially the initial few months, is pivotal with Olympic qualification on the line. No Indian man has won an Olympic medal in badminton, with Saina Nehwal and P.V. Sindhu having contributed to the three-medal haul, but none gold. One can bet on Chirag and Satwiksairaj to want to etch their names in the history books. Given the year they've had, their growing belief in their abilities and their love for Paris—where the duo has won two titles—there's good reason to put SatChi's names alongside javelin thrower and reigning Olympic champion Neeraj Chopra as medal favourites. ■